

ORIGINS



Michael Naify



Præciosum Tamen Nigrvm "The Precious Black, However"
Small tabernacle in honor of Barão Paraopeba
Congonhas, MG

FORWARD

As both a historian and a photographer, I have always believed that the role of images is not merely to record what is seen, but to reveal the deeper truths embedded in place and memory. *Origins* was born from that impulse – an attempt to engage with a history at once glorious and grievous, a history of “*exploração*” in Minas Gerais, Brazil – a word whose dual meaning, exploration and exploitation, captures the essence of this land’s past with unsettling precision.

The very name Minas Gerais – meaning “General Mines” – speaks to the centrality of extraction here. This is a state nearly the size of France, defined for centuries by what lay beneath its soil. In these coffee-stained cyanotypes – one of photography’s earliest processes, discovered in the mid-19th century – I sought to evoke the Iron Triangle where I worked, its earth saturated with the world’s richest veins of iron ore. This mineral abundance fed colonial coffers then, just as it fuels global industries now. But the iron that built railways, weapons, and empire was mined by enslaved people. Their forced labor underpinned the gold rush of the 17th century, which was itself only a prelude to the iron industry’s expansion. When abolition finally arrived in Brazil in 1888 – the last country in the Americas to do so – it was abolition in name only. The structures that upheld slavery endured, embedded in institutions and landscapes alike.

The staining of these cyanotypes with coffee is not merely aesthetic alteration. Coffee itself, like iron, was a product of forced labor in Brazil’s plantations. This staining process is thus an act of historical evocation. It makes visible what is too often ignored: that these commodities – iron, gold, coffee, and human lives – were inextricably entangled in a vast transatlantic economy of extraction. The images become not only representations, but remnants – shadows of the people and systems that created them.

As a historian, I am struck by the Estrada Real – the Royal Road – which snakes from Paraty on the coast into the interior towns like Diamantina, a city named for its diamonds. It was no mere road but a conduit of supremacy, a meticulously engineered artery designed to siphon Brazil’s riches to Portugal while binding its destiny in dependency. The colonial design was deliberate: Brazil would provide raw materials; Portugal would provide manufactured goods. An education system deliberately stunted; an economy deliberately shackled. Such was the architecture of empire. These are not abstractions but structures that conditioned daily life and entrenched hierarchies so deeply that even capitalism, as it emerged, adapted itself seamlessly to them. The historian in me sees the iron grip of these systems; the photographer in me sees their marks on earth, architecture, and faces.

Yet amid these bitter legacies, there endures something luminous. The hybrid cultures that emerged from this crucible are today among Brazil’s greatest treasures. Ouro Preto, Congonhas, and Diamantina remain breathtakingly beautiful, UNESCO World Heritage Sites that testify to both ambition and avarice. But beyond monuments, there is something more profound: the resilience of the people themselves. For if colonialism and slavery bequeathed art, architecture, and music, they also forged the greatest legacy of all – resistance. In the capacity to survive, adapt, and defy domination, there is a cultural brilliance that no empire could extinguish. That, above all, is what these images seek to honor.

Michael Naify: ORIGINS

Shannon Botelho

Deep marks — invisible to the hurried eye — carry stories that the earth, iron, and the body insist on revealing. It is in this silent intertwining of matter and memory that *Origens* (Origins) is born, an exhibition composed of a series of cyanotypes that Michael Naify presents to the public at the Centro Cultural dos Correios. The exhibition is the result of the impact caused by his arrival in Minas Gerais in 2019, when he encountered the aftermath of the Vale mining dam collapse in Brumadinho — a tragedy that resulted in the deaths of 270 people and caused devastating social, environmental, and economic consequences. Moved by the news, Naify used his eye as a historian and photographer to undertake a sensitive investigation into the roots of that disaster. What emerged was not just an isolated catastrophe, but the continuation, albeit in different ways, of a torment that runs through countries marked by colonization — such as Brazil and the United States —: the permanence of structures based on exploitation, whether through slavery in the past or the unequal gears of capitalism.

Photography, unlike painting, does not construct reality—it captures it, albeit in an edited, fragmented form, marked by choices. In this sense, Naify's images do not seek to erase or reconstruct the past from a colonizing perspective. On the contrary, they operate as a gesture of revelation of the violence inscribed in historically constituted social relations, exposed here through an artistic process that combines technique, matter, and memory. Cyanotype, a photographic process based on the use of iron salts that results in bluish tones, has been reinterpreted here. The artist incorporated coffee into the emulsion, replacing blue with brown—a symbolic gesture that refers to the commodities that founded the colonial system, to the exploitation that sustained both slavery and modern capitalism.

In the works, there is a field of tension between technical rigor and the physicality of the gesture: brushstrokes, smudges, scratches, and other marks from the process are not erased—on the contrary, they remain visible, like scars on the image. Time is also inscribed in these fractures: the time that passes, that corrodes and reveals; time as duration and vestige. Naify merges matter and symbolism to create a poetics of memory — a memory that emerges from the soil, the body, and struggle. Upon entering this territory, he moves away from the comfort of whiteness and aligns himself with those who, in Brazil and around the world, are at the forefront of the struggle for social and racial justice.

The exhibition is organized around four axes—metallurgy and mining, faith and religiosity, humanity and slavery, landscape and colonization—which unfold the multiple layers of Brazilian origins. Each axis reveals tensions between beauty and brutality, memory and silence, resistance and erasure, reflecting the complexity of a history that is present and active. The images are produced sometimes with coffee, sometimes with oxides that give them bluish tones, uniting matter and symbol in an artistic gesture that materializes the memory of the land, the body, and exploitation. Far from rigidly dividing the exhibition, these themes dialogue with each other, allowing the images to transition and unfold in multiple and transversal meanings.

At the entrance to the exhibition, a self-representation of the artist—a self-portrait with a pig mask—presents the investigative mark that runs through his work: an inquiry into identity, the gaze, and the role of the artist in the shadows of history. By concealing his own face under the face of an animal that, in the American financial imagination, symbolizes greed and brutality, Naify highlights his place as a subject implicated in the systems he denounces. In this sense, the photographs that make up *Origens* emerge as an extension of this inaugural gesture — they capture shadows, echoes, and traces of a past that refuses to pass. They invite the viewer to look beyond the surface and confront the complexity of their own origins.

The photographs of objects, spaces, and memories preserved in the Slave Museum in Belo Vale (MG), and found by the artist during his research, provoked the emotional impact that gave meaning and purpose to the images we see here—a record that seeks to capture the shadows, echoes, and marks of the past. Mining, with its iron veins cutting through the landscape, also enters into a dialogue with the scrap yard—a space of metal waste that echoes the continuity of metal extraction and transformation, connecting the colonial past and contemporary exploitation. Faith, between colonizing Catholicism and syncretism, reveals the spiritual dimensions intertwined with power; slavery, a structural wound, leaves its indelible marks; and the landscape, both stage and witness, reveals the paradox between erasure and memory.

The colonial past, marked by the brutality of slavery and mineral extraction, is not a closed chapter, but a living present that manifests itself in social and economic structures. Capitalism, colonialism, and their political systems were built on contempt for human life, transforming bodies into commodities—a legacy that, despite formal abolition, persists in countless forms. It is this complexity and resistance that the series *Origens* invites us to recognize, exposing traces that resist the passage of time, revealing open wounds and silenced narratives.

Photography, beyond mere recording, becomes an act of resistance and revelation. As Roland Barthes aptly points out in *Camera Lucida* (1980), photography is the encounter between time and eternity—an instant that was and remains, a mark that transcends time. In Naify's cyanotypes, this dimension manifests itself in the materiality of the image and in the symbolic charge of the elements used, inviting the viewer to traverse layers of memory and face the past in all its complexity and ambiguity.

Origens does not offer itself as a definitive narrative, but as a sensitive invitation to revisit the many stories of Brazil — or non-stories, marked by hegemonic narratives that insist on silencing other voices. The exhibition listens attentively to these echoes that resist oblivion, recognizing open wounds and lingering traces, so that we may open paths to new narratives, plural and welcoming, capable of embracing the multiplicity of experiences that shape our identity. Between shadows and traces, wounds and resistance, it is in the deep understanding of what grounds us that the strength to reinvent the present and explore possible futures springs forth.

Shannon Botelho

2025

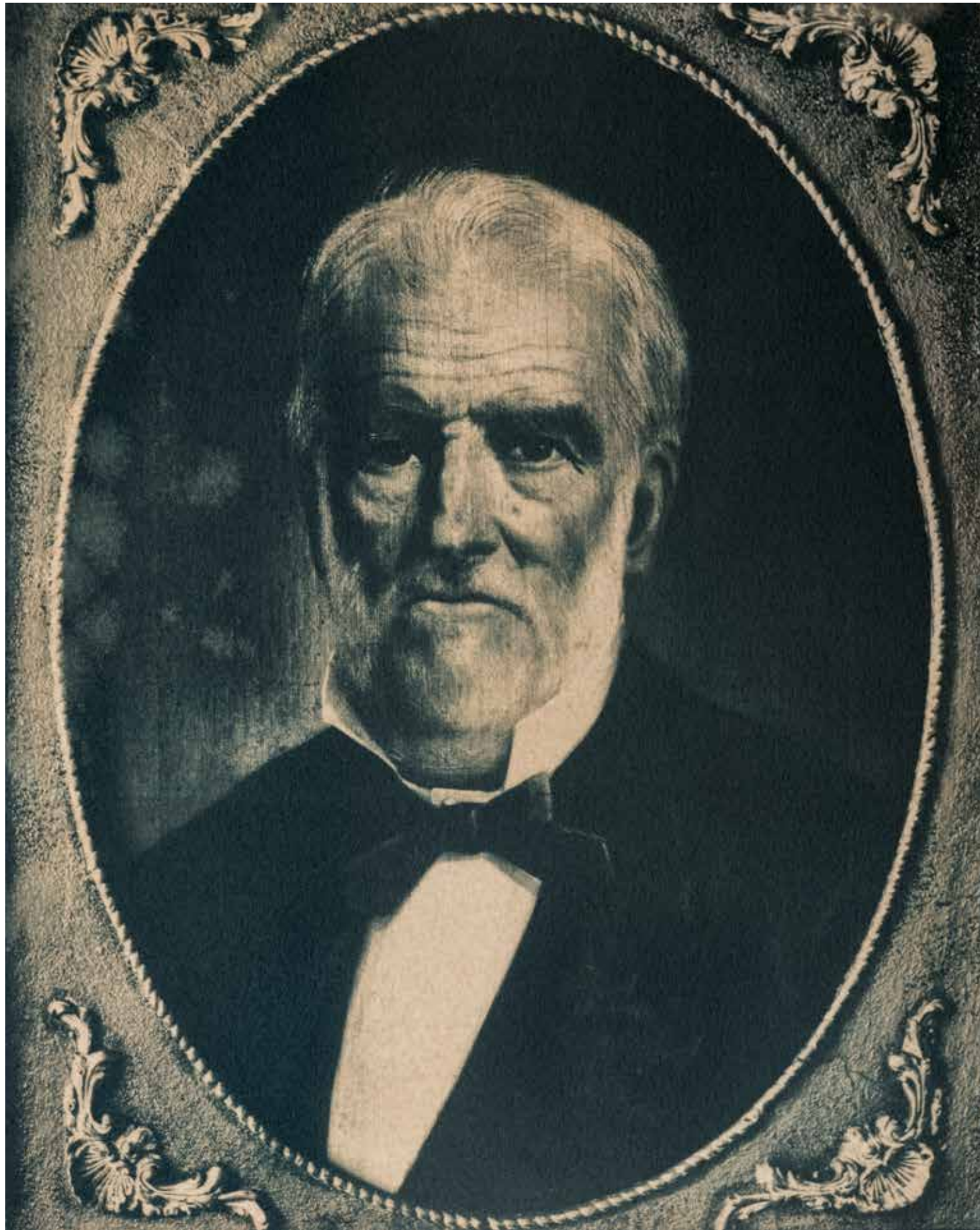


DOMINION

Self Portrait, Alter-Ego
His name is Greed, and he live in each of us.



The Baron
Romualdo José Monteiro de Barros
Statesman, founder of Brazil's first iron foundry
Colonel of Melitia, Knight of the Imperial Order of Christ
Estate of Baron de Paraopeba



Baroness Margarida Eufrásia da Cunha Matos
Heiress to gold mine in Ouro Preto
Estate of Baron de Paraopeba



Limoges porcelain - Set table
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba

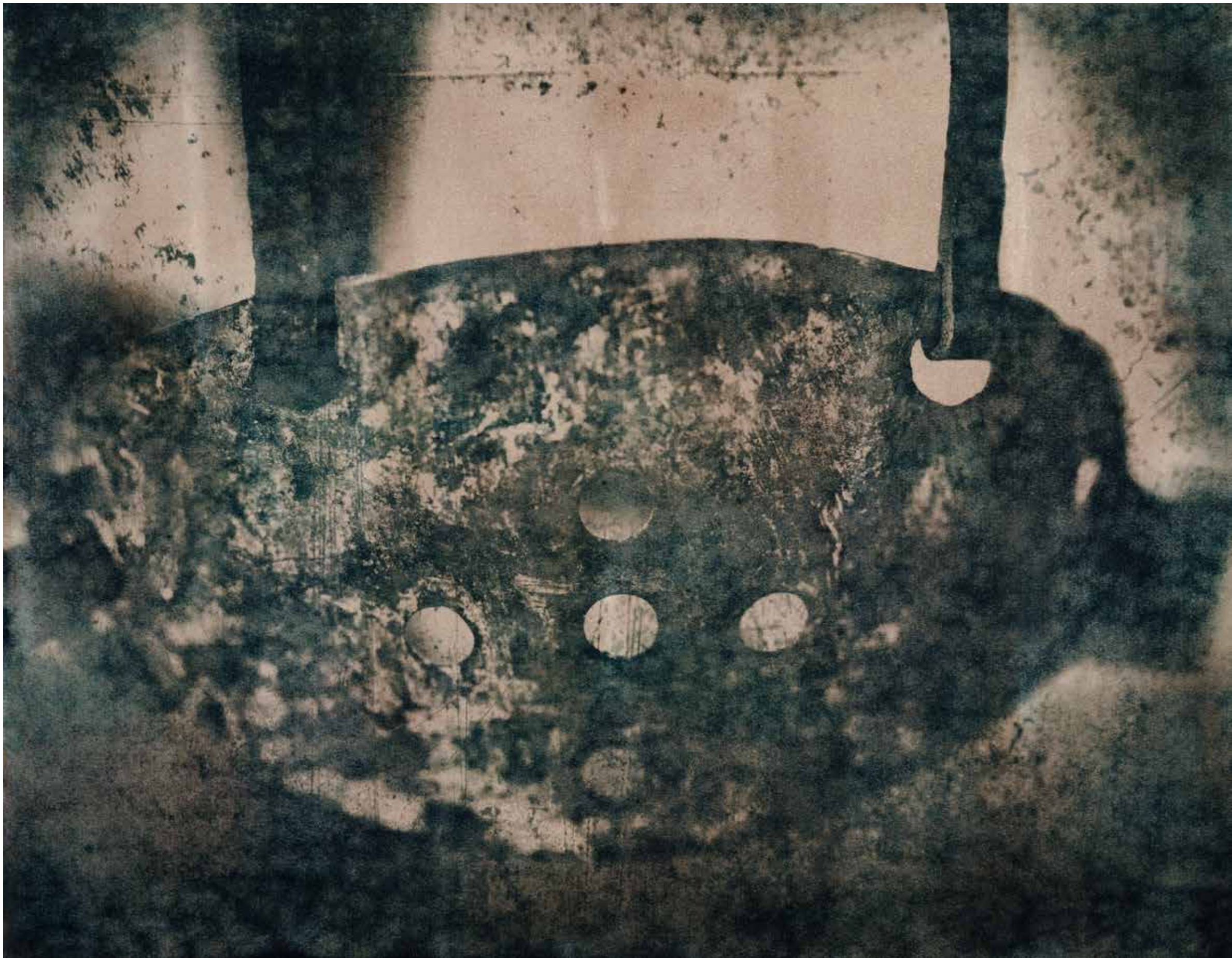




19th Century silver samovar

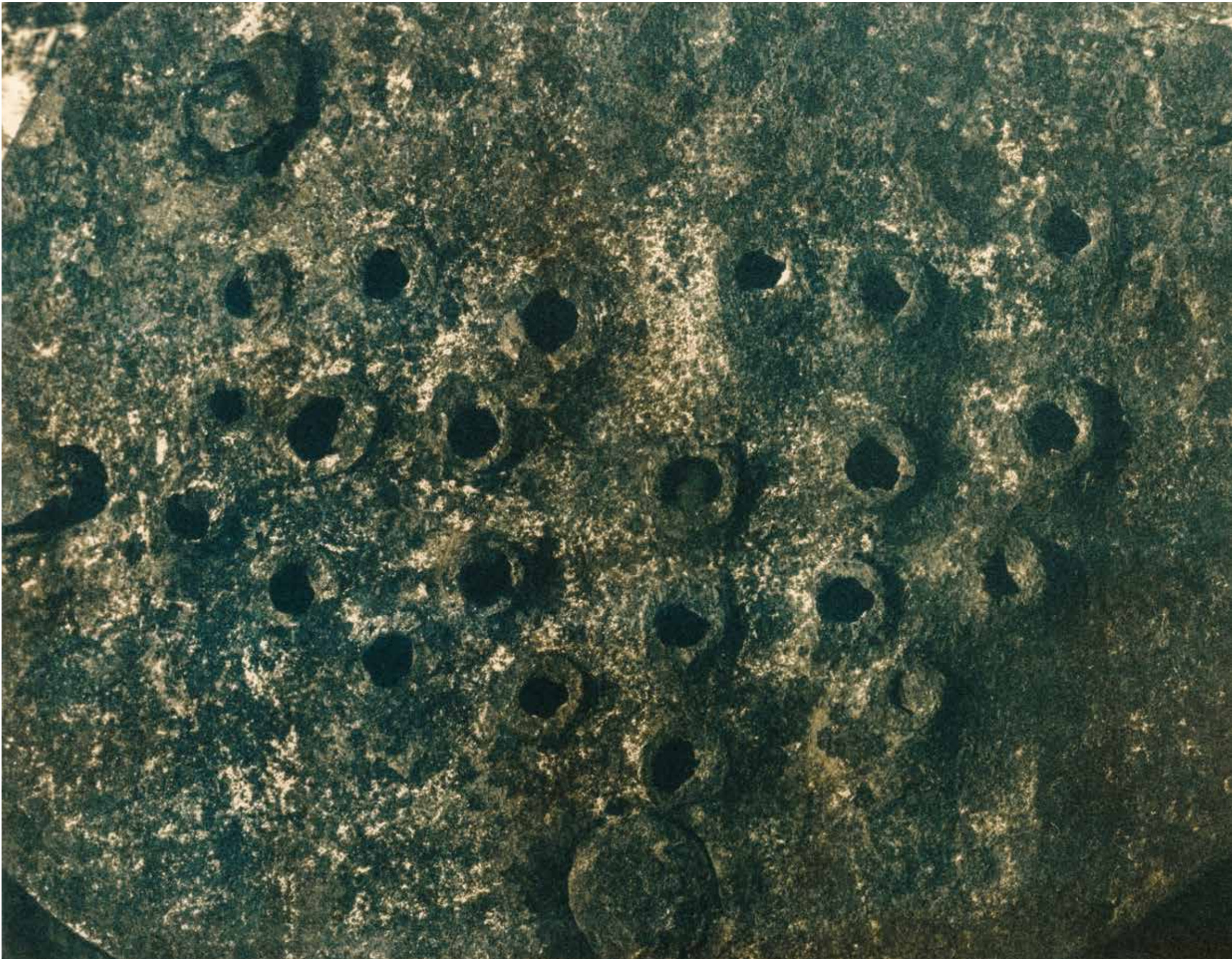


Fasting mask for kitchen servants
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba



Punishment Collar (Detail)
Belo Vale, MG



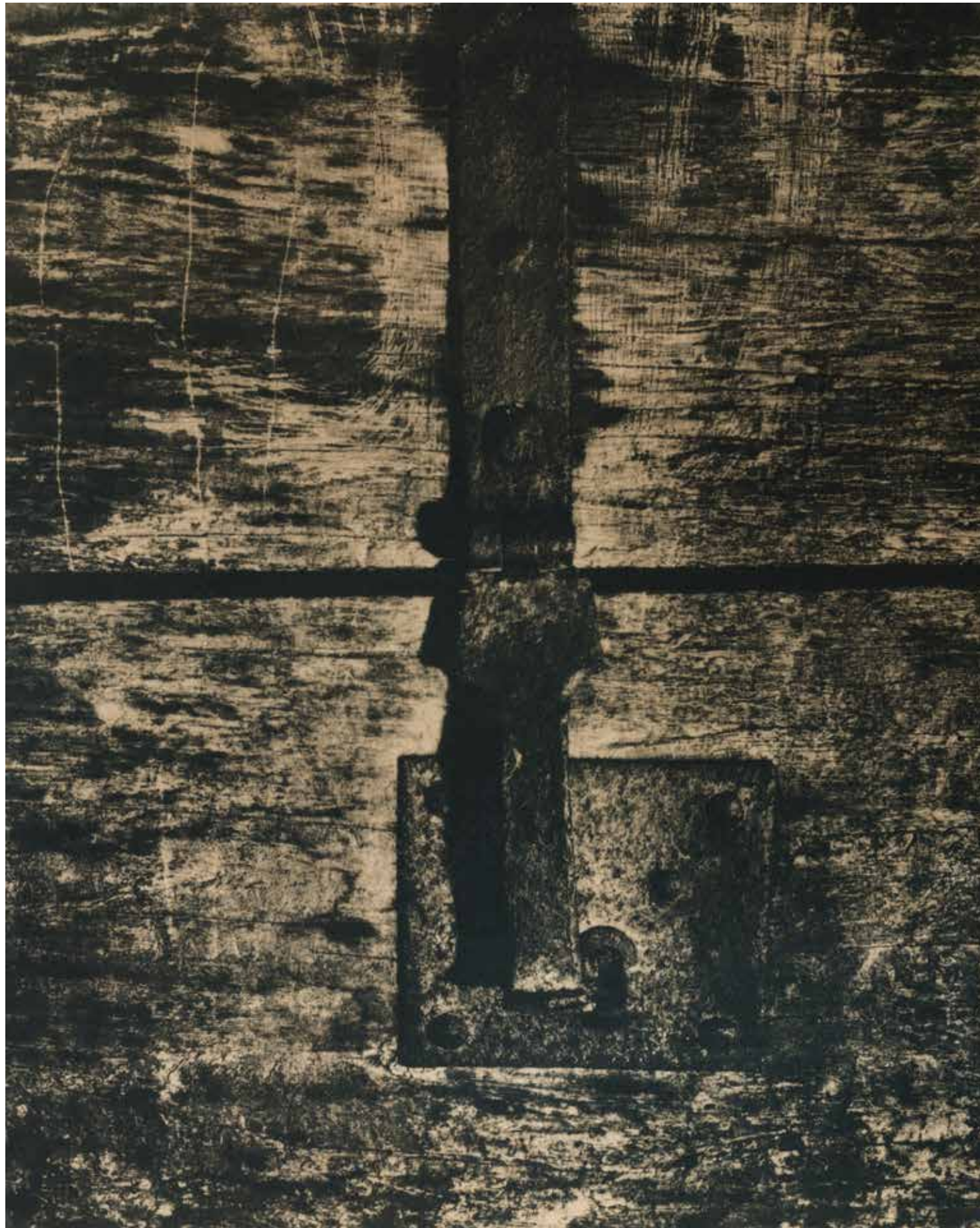


Fasting Mask (Close up)
Belo Vale, MG



Stockade
From estate of Baron de Paraopeba
Belo Vale, MG

Stockade lock
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba





Iron neck ring
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba

LIBERTY, EVEN IF LATE

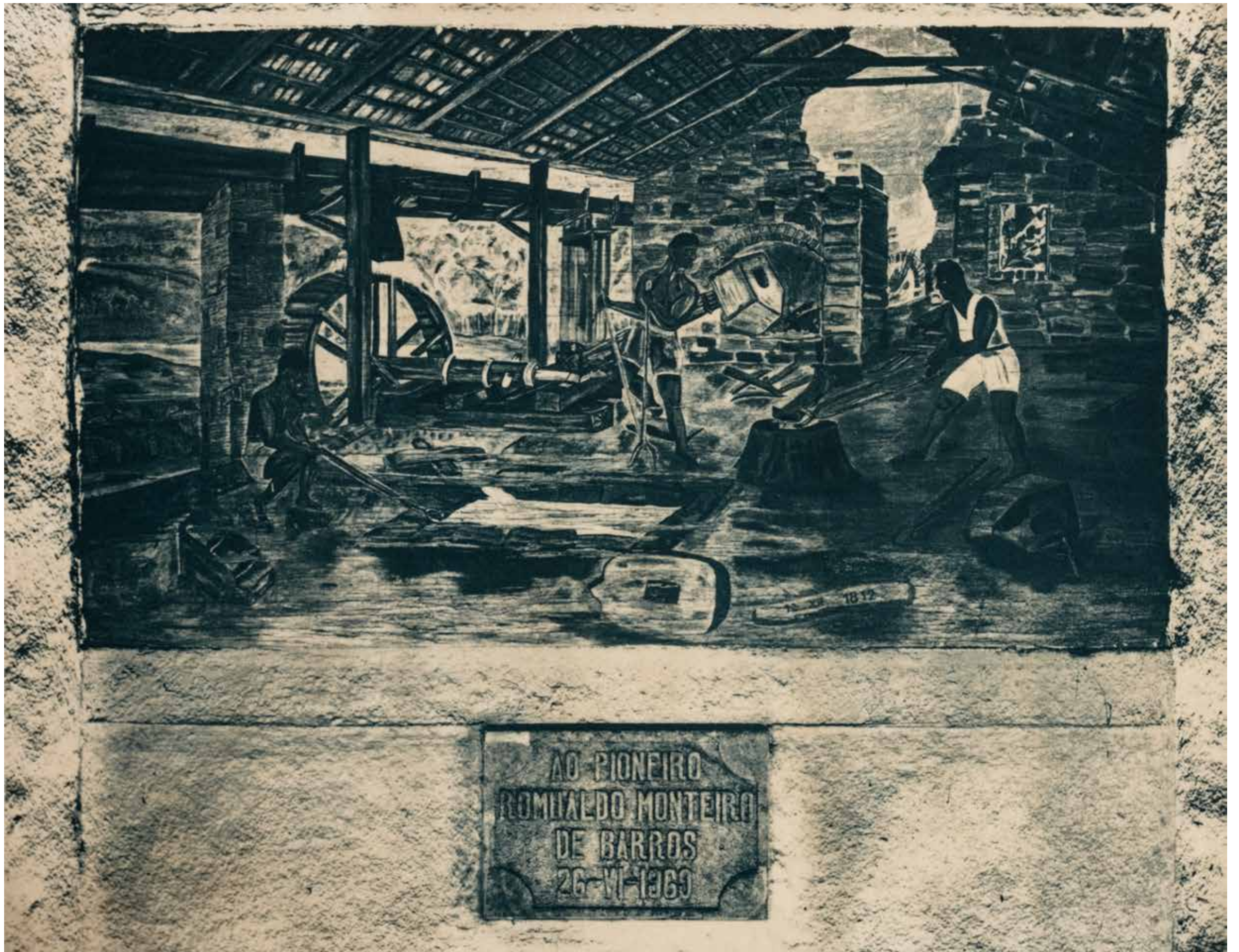
Expression from the separatist movement (1789) not related to slave emancipation.
Fabrica Patriotica, Minas Gerais



Prætiosum Tamen Nigrum
“Precious Yet Black”
Found at Shrine to Baron de Paraopeba
Congonhas, MG



Tabernacle celebrating the achievements of the Baron de Paraopeba
Fabrica Patriotica, Minas Gerais



Ancestral Home of Toquinha
(Head of Quilombola Chacrinha dos Pretos)
(Stolen by White Farmers)





EXTRACTION

ing Com-

Exit Mine Cata Branca Mine
(Hundreds of Slaves Drowned After Mine Collapse (1840))
Itabirito, MG



Burned Tree at Edge of Mine
Congonhas, MG



Gold mine (excavated by children)
Ouro Preto, Minas Gerais



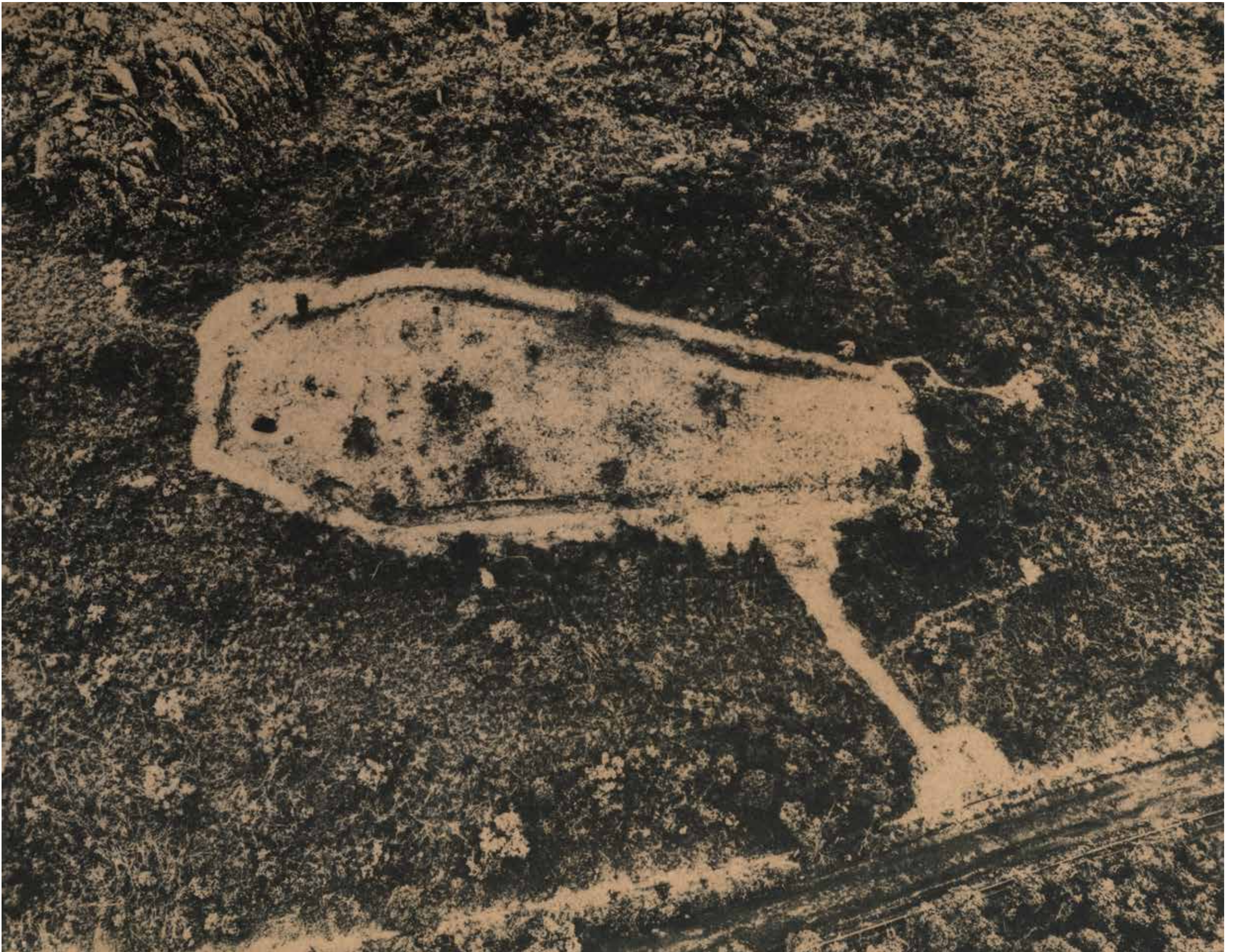
Burned forest next to active mine.
Congonhas, Minas Gerais



Detritus in the debris field of the Brumadinho tailings dam disaster
in which killed 272 people in 2019.
Brumadinho, Minas Gerais



“The English Cemetary” at the Cata Branca mine. It was only
meant for management no slaves were entombed here.
Itabirito, Minas Gerais





Abandoned Tailings Dam.
Congonhas, Minas Gerais

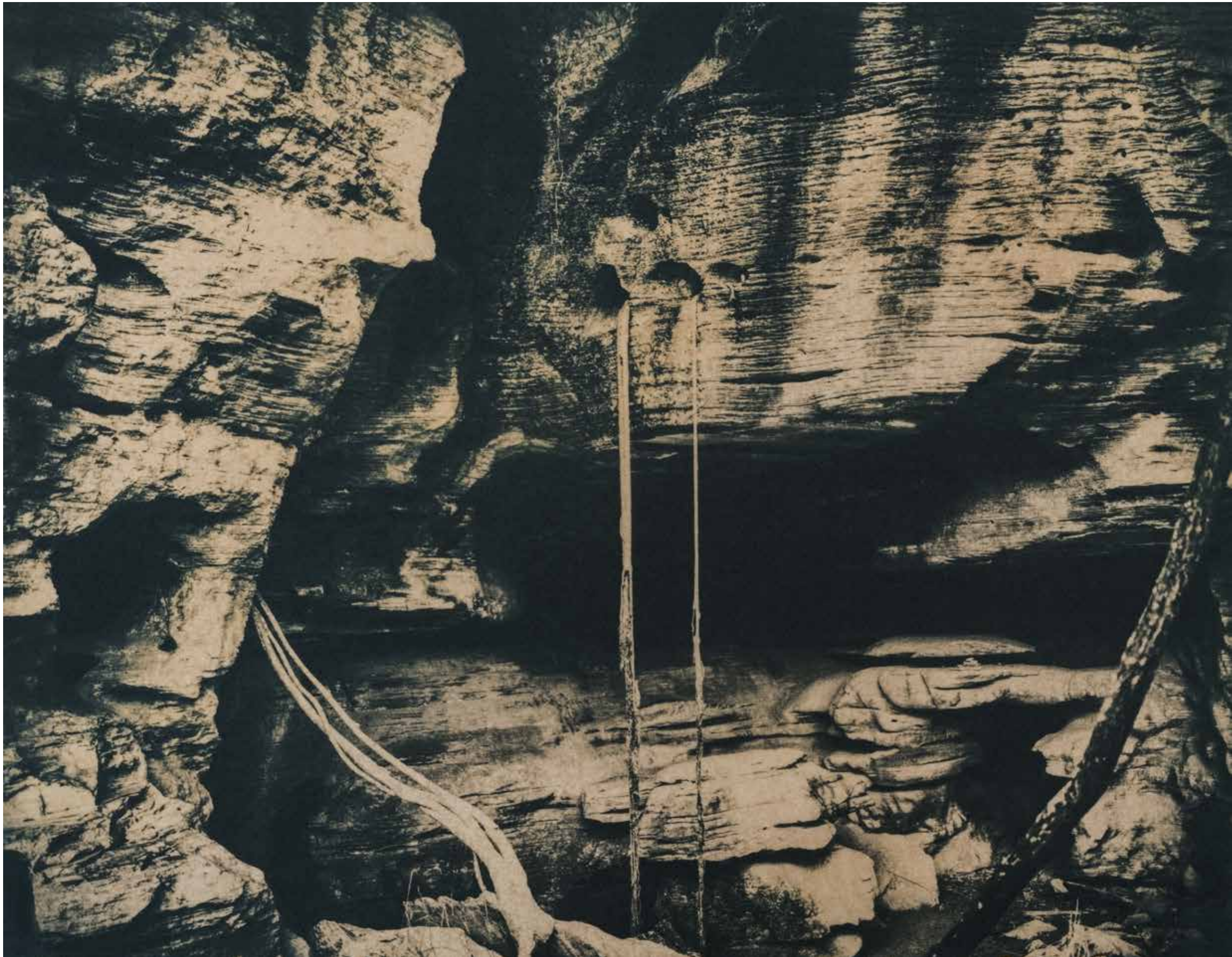


Ruins: Cata Branca
Itabirito, MG

Bleeding wall
Cata Branca, Minas Gerais



Grota
Parque Estadual do Sumidouro, Minas Gerais



Burned tree in preparation of mine expansion.
Congonhas, Minas Gerais





Termite Mound
Congonhas, MG

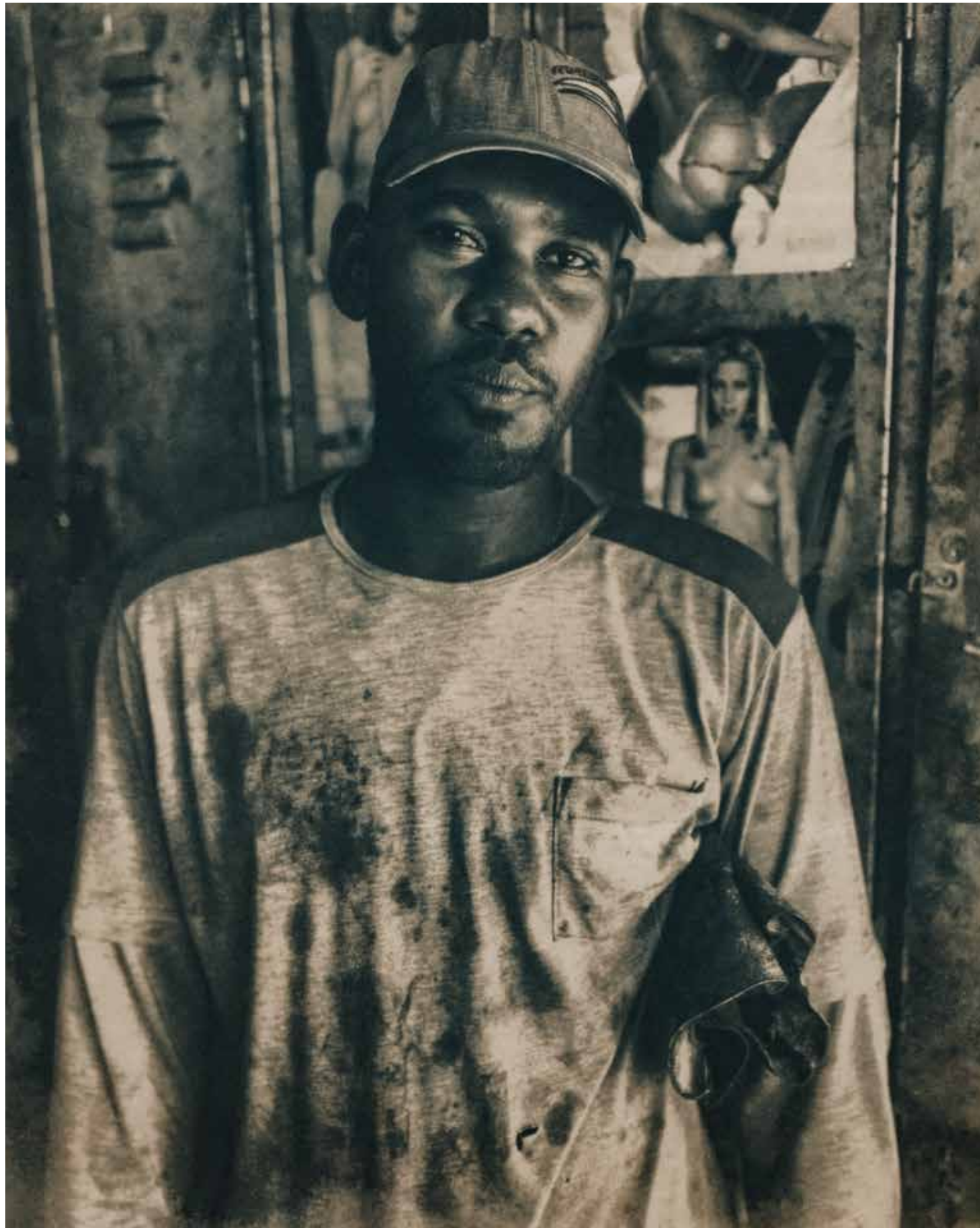


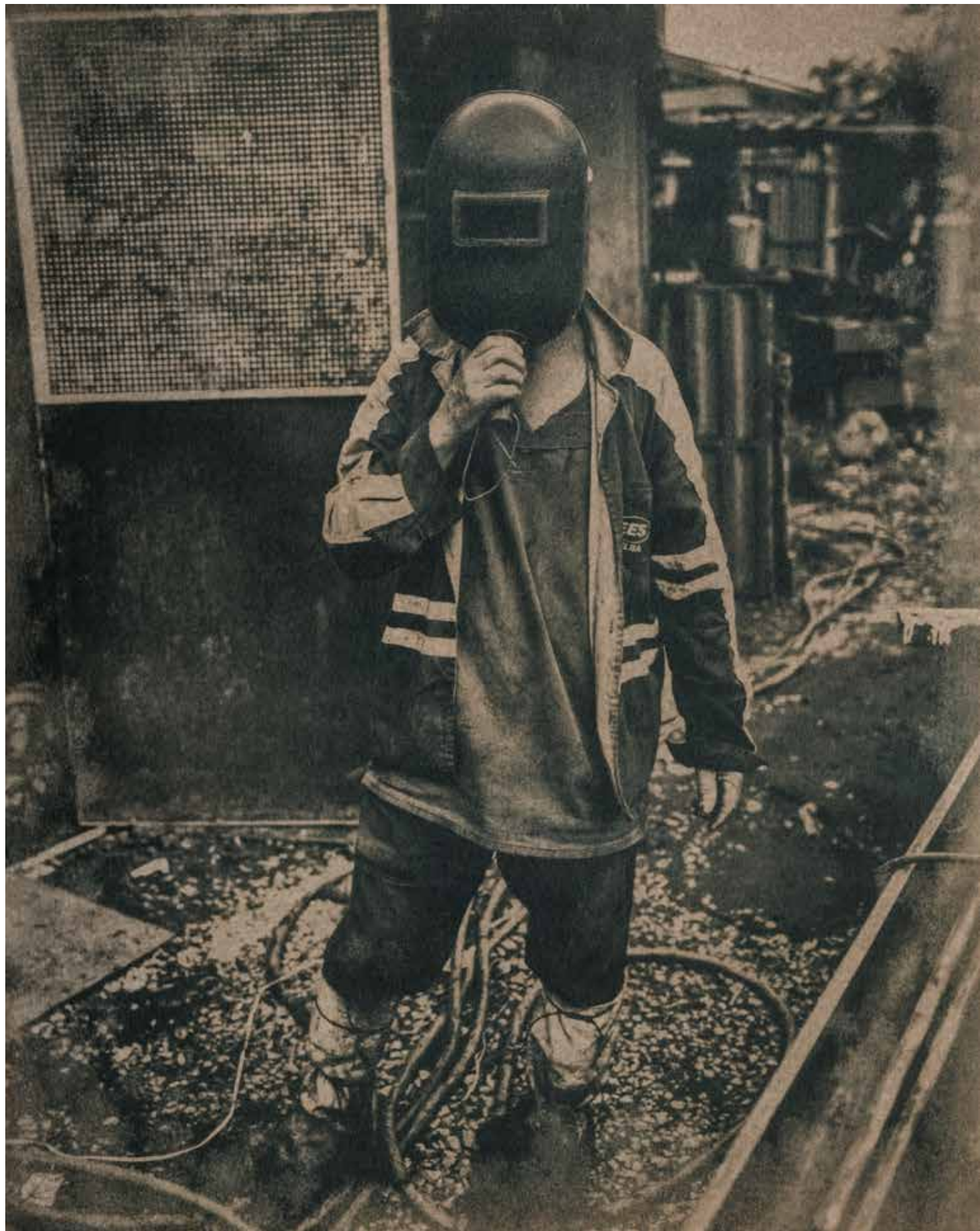
LABOR



Iron Workers Hands
Contagem, BH

Milton - Scrap Iron Worker
Contagem, Minas Gerais





Masked Iron Worker
Contagem, MG

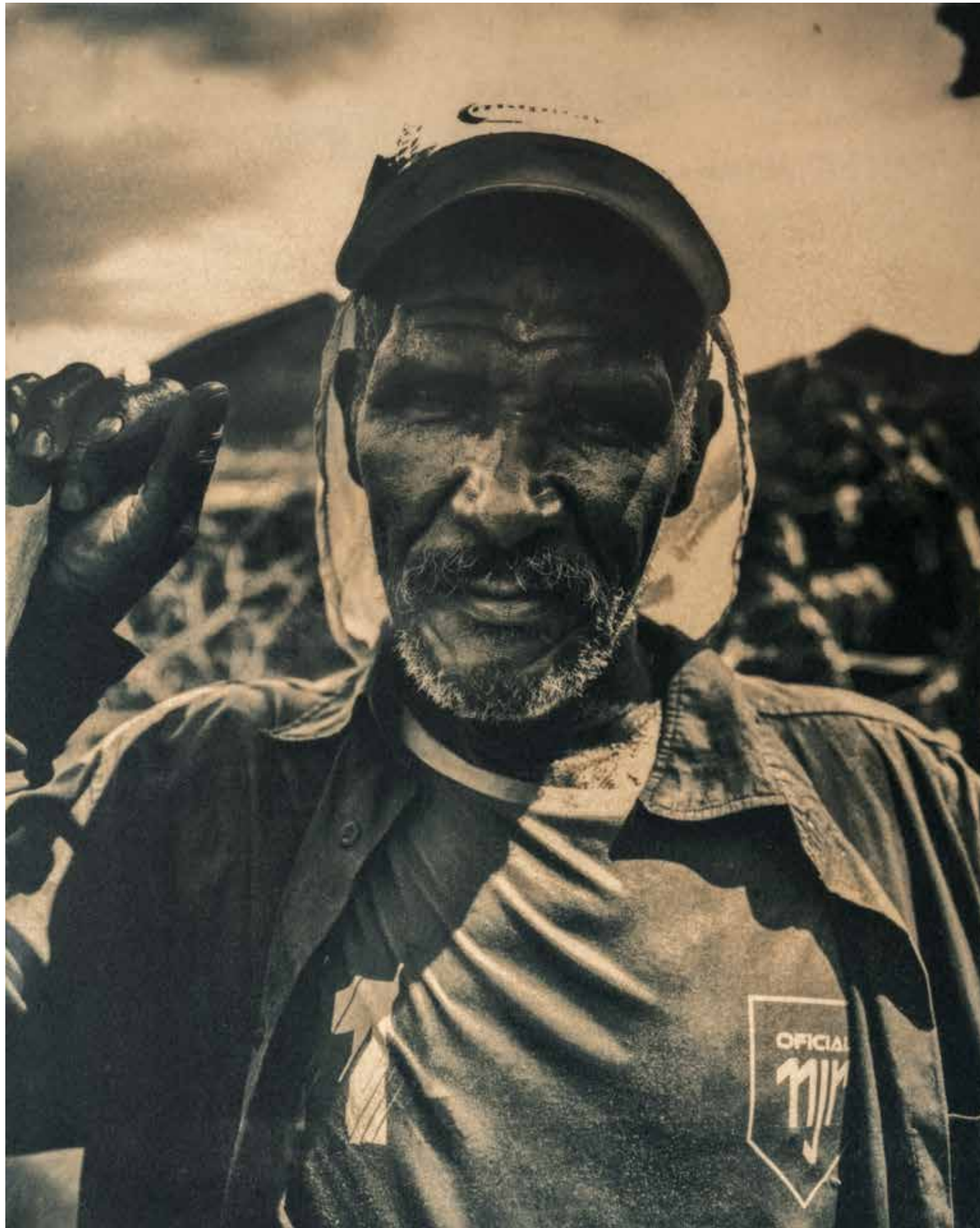


Iron Worker
Contagem, MG



Amanda
Belo Vale, MG

Farmer
Brumadinho, Minas Gerais



Meat delivery
Sabará, Minas Gerais



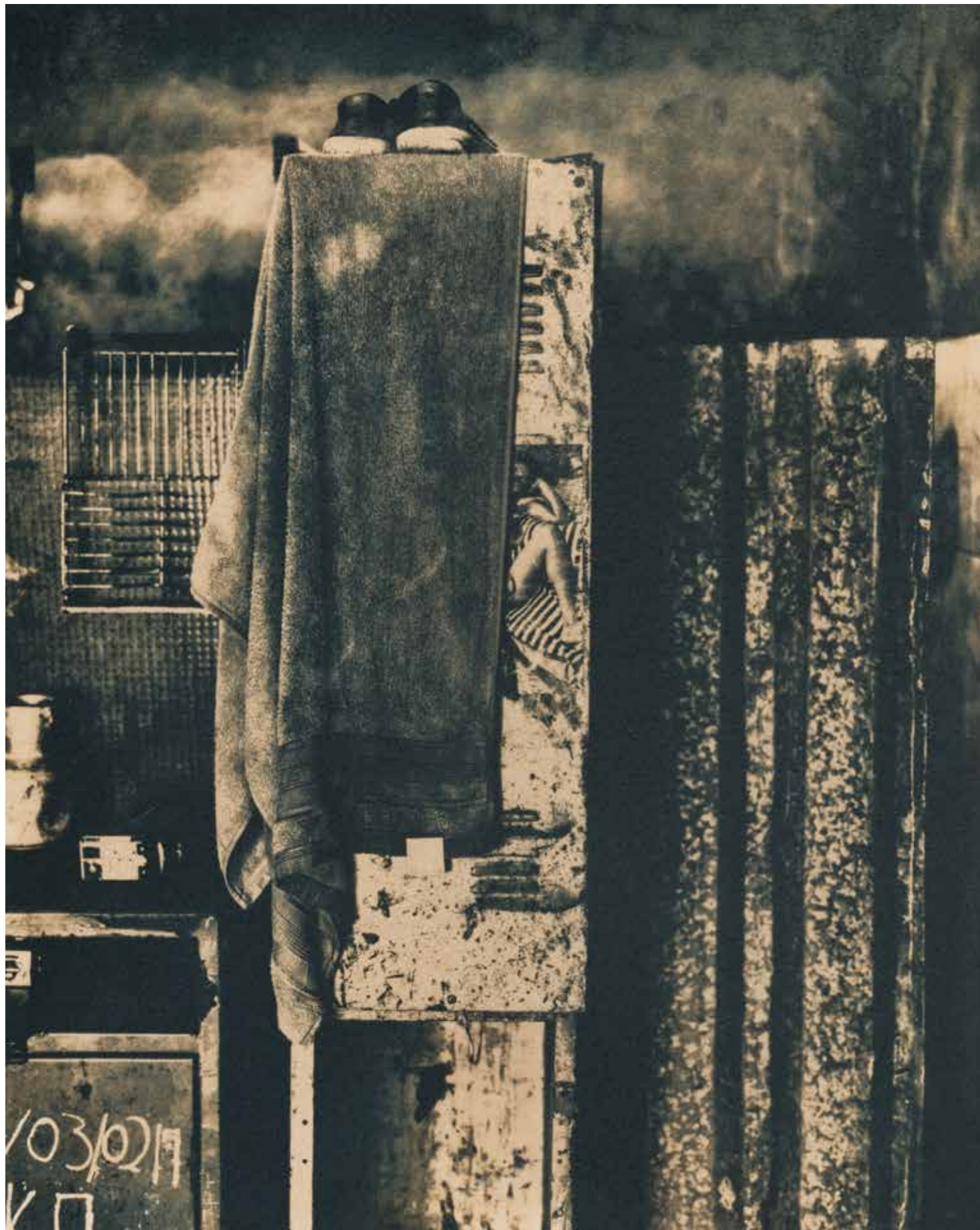
Scrap Iron
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Junk Yard
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Changing room
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Junk Yard Cafeteria
Contagem, Minas Gerais





Abandoned train station for iron ore
Brumadinho, Minas Gerais

Scrap Iron Worker (John)
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Wonder Woman
Contagem, Minas Gerais

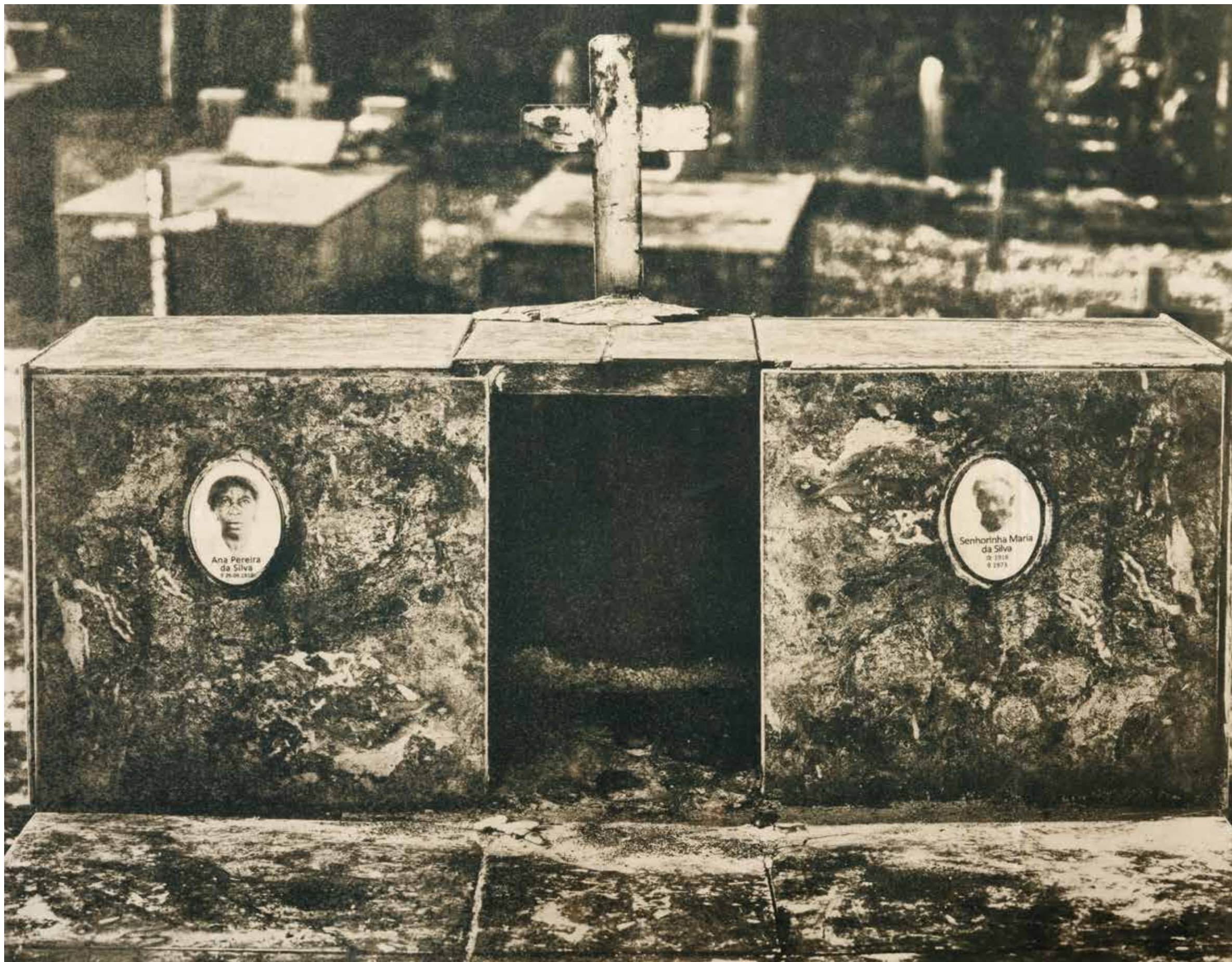


Abandoned Volkswagen
Contagem, Minas Gerais



RELIGION

Cemetery
Quilombo de Boa Morte, Minas Gerais





Cous Cous Steamer (Inheratance of Toquinha)
Quilombola Chacrinha dos Pretos, MG



Eye of Saint
Ouro Preto, MG



Eye of Saint (Shock)
Ouro Preto, MG

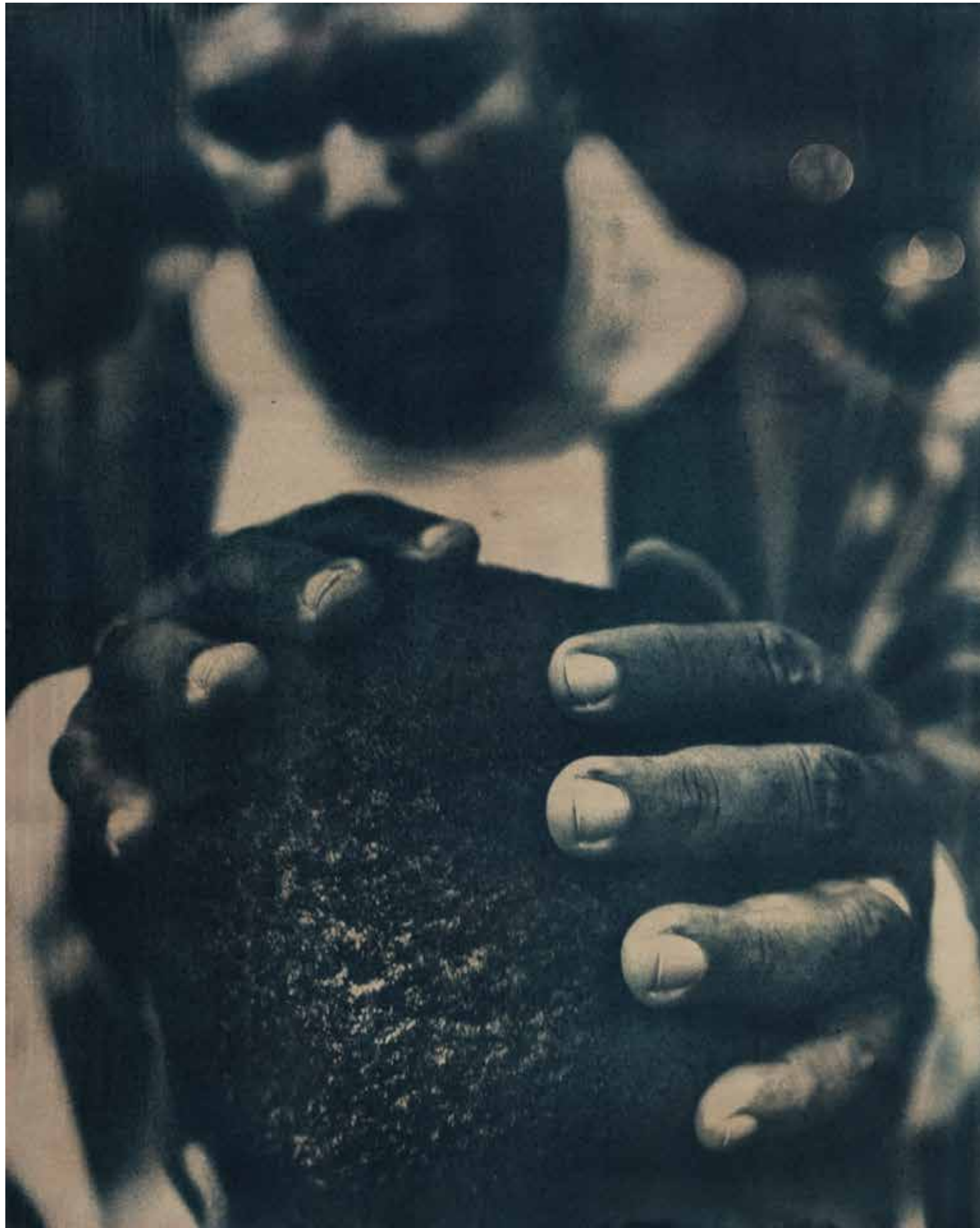


Pietà
Belo Horizonte, MG

Christ in repose
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais



The Blessing



Hand of Saint
Congonhas, Minas Gerais



Christ Carrying the Cross



Truck Stop
BR 040 , Minas Gerais



Angel of Belo Horizonte
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais





Green House
Botanical Garden,
Belo Horizonte, MG



Talisman
Itabirito, MG



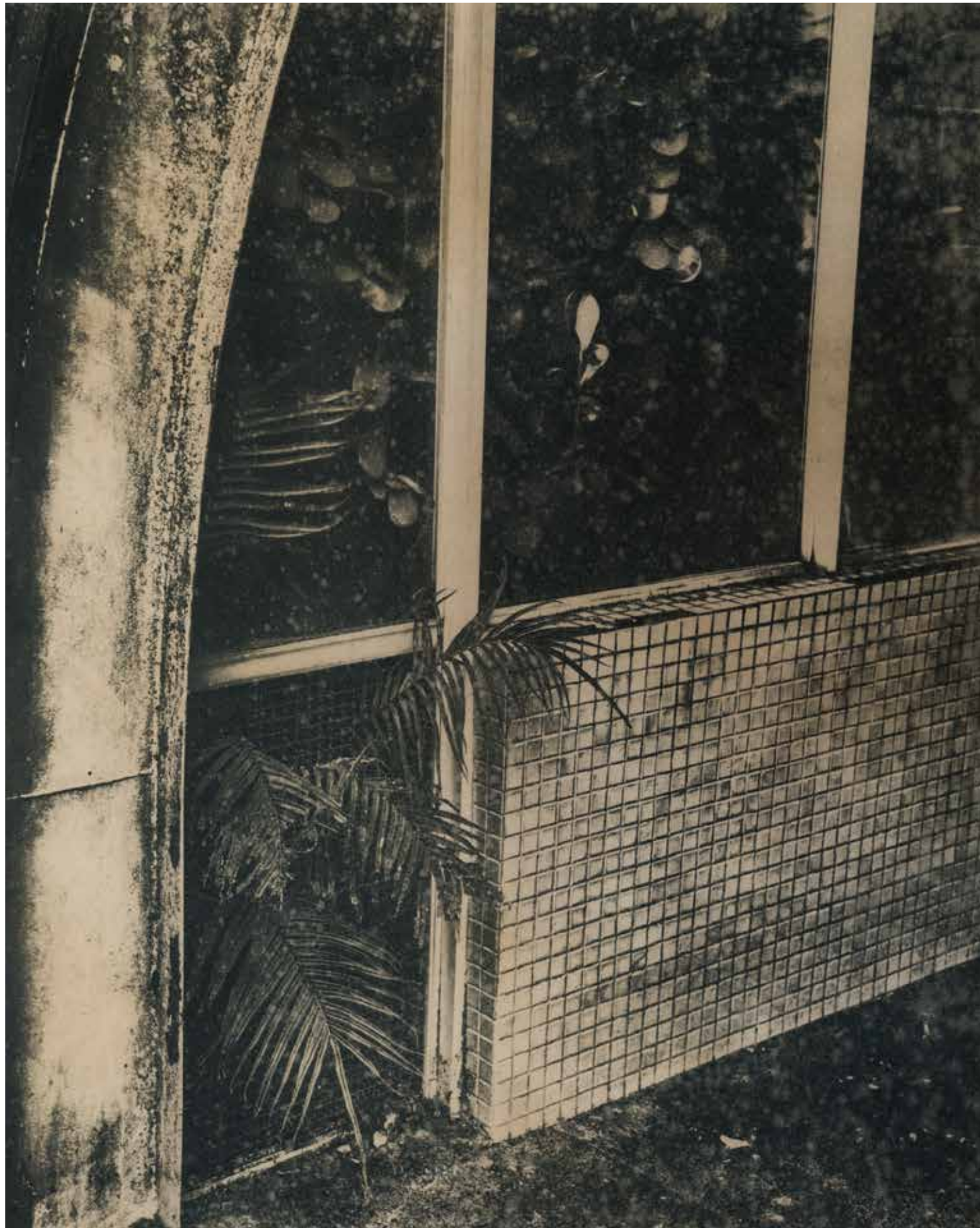
Self portrait in the courtyard of the Baron's home
Belo Vale, Minas Gerais

Stalking wolf
favela de Serra
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais



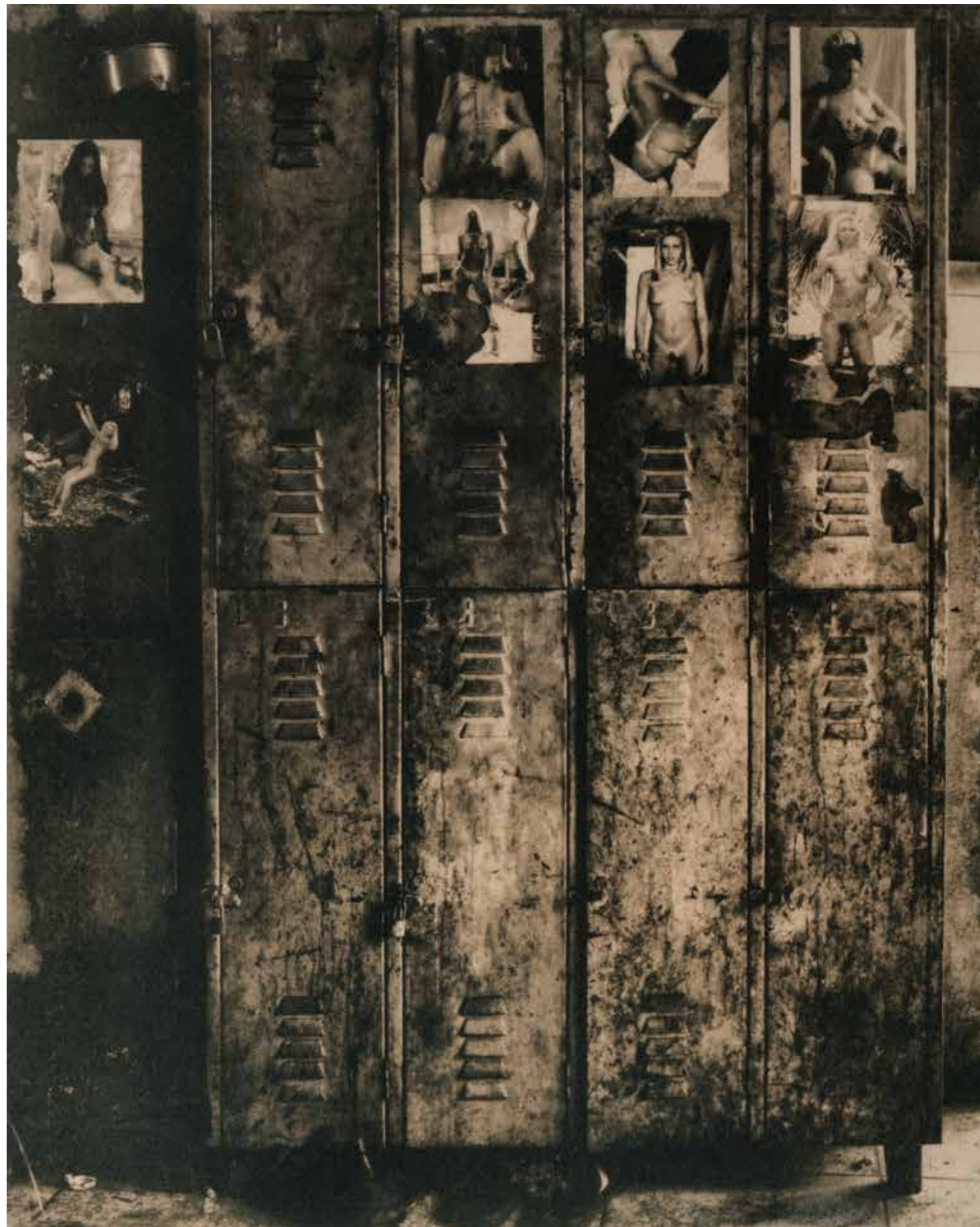
Saint
Sabará, Minas Gerais





Botanical garden
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais

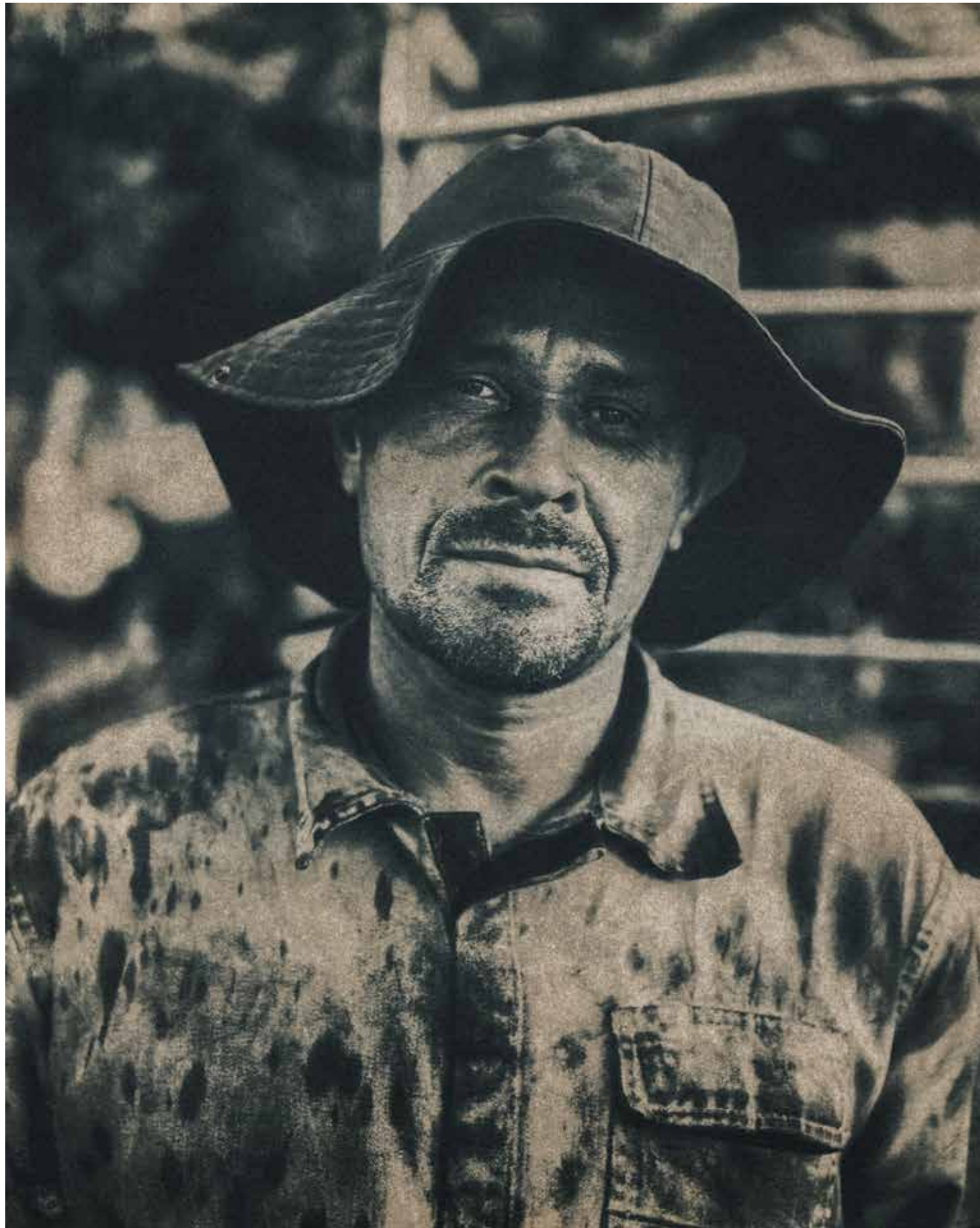
Changing room
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Junkyard Dog
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Scrap iron worker
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Sandals in Changing Room
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Pin-up Girl on Locker Door
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Teddy Bear
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Scrap Iron Workers
Contagem, Minas Gerais



Detail of Crucified Christ
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais





LANDSCAPES



Three Palms (Dead)
Brumadinho, MG

Grota de Macumba
Parque Estadual do Sumidouro, Minas Gerais



Fort Brumadinho
Serra da Calçada, Minas Gerais



Cata Branca Ruins
Itabirito, Minas Gerais



Cata Branca Ruins
Itabirito, Minas Gerais



Cata Branca Ruins
Itabirito, Minas Gerais



Cata Branca Ruins
Itabirito, Minas Gerais



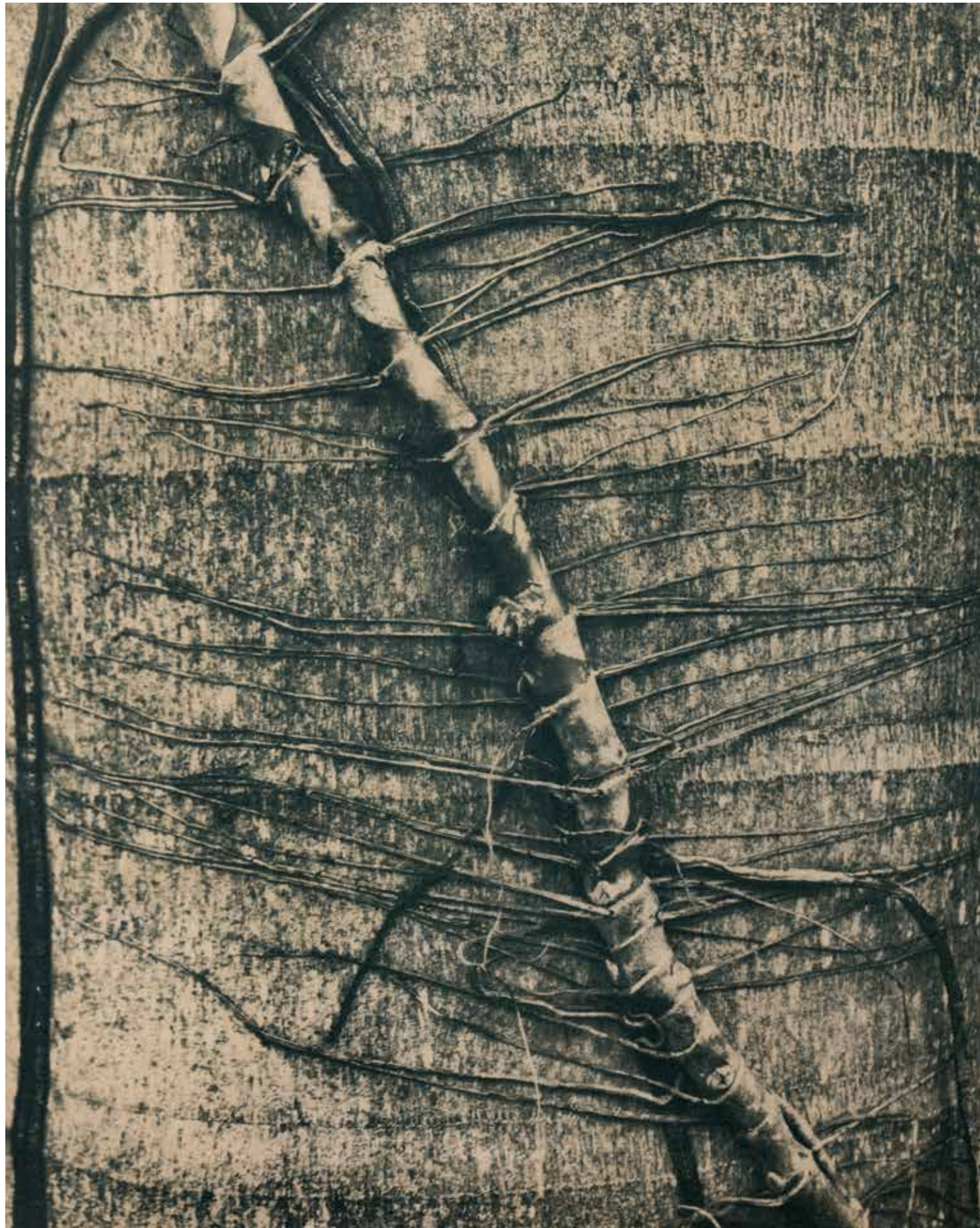
Rake
Brumadinho, Minas Gerais



Palm
Brumadinho, Minas Gerais

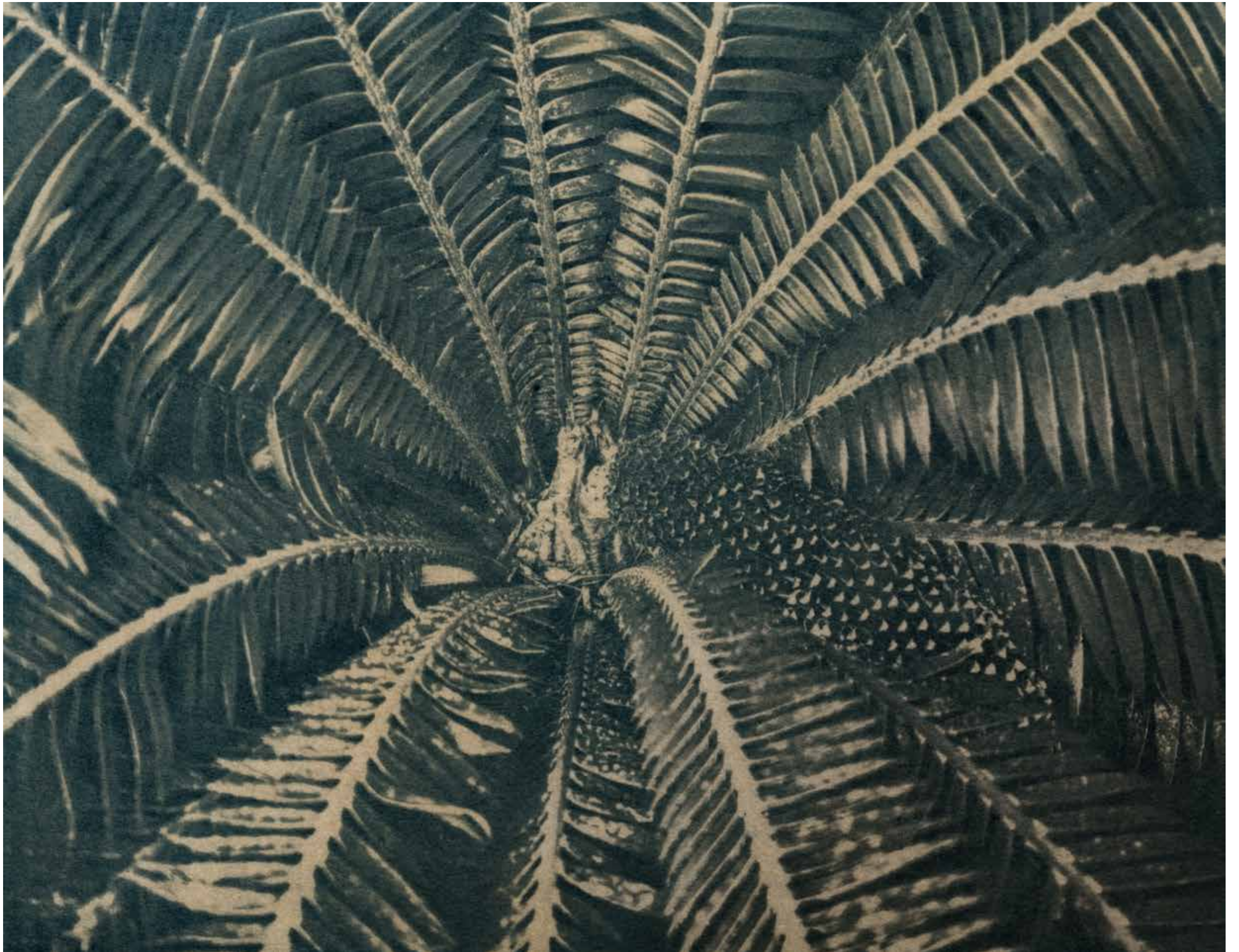


Creeping vine
São João del Rei, Minas Gerais



Fallen Fruit
Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais







Mattress in Debris Field Brumadinho
Brumadinho, MG



Fasting Mask (Estate of Baron de Paraopeba)
Belo Vale, MG



Scrap Iron
Contagem, MG



Grota
Belo Vale, MG

Stockade (Detail)
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba



Stockade (Detail)
Estate of the Baron de Paraopeba



Origins, the first exhibition by American photographer Michael Naify in Brazil (Rio de Janeiro), begins with Self-Portrait. The image depicts a hybrid being, part man, part animal, holding a flower (a milkweed) in his hands, which seems to emerge, erect, from the dark rocky walls of a mine. His feet, dug into the crumbled rocks on the ground, give the impression of floating in space; his light body, in contrast to the darkness of the environment, detaches itself from the rest of the image, as if projected into the air.

The symbolism of the artist's representation as a mutant being does not go unnoticed. Mutant because he is simultaneously attached to the ground and loose in space; confined to his world and wanting to go beyond it. Mutant because the human body and animal head (pig) are reminiscent of the Hindu god Vishnu, who comes into the world as an avatar, able to take on, among other forms, that of a man with a boar's head (matter/spirit, destruction/creation).

The theme of destruction and ruins permeates Michael's creative work. His photographs (cyanotypes), taken between 2018 and 2024 in the Estrada Real region of Minas Gerais, depict fragments of objects, mine shafts and abandoned stations, ancient coats of arms and emblems, dilapidated buildings, shackles, instruments of intimidation and torture, fallen fruit, debris, bodies, faces. They show the other side, the perverse side of an untold story, of a memory of exploitation and desolation that is meant to be forgotten.

The nature of his iconographic narrative evokes the emblematic figure of Angelus Novus (drawing by Paul Klee, 1920), as used by Walter Benjamin (1940) in his well-known philosophical proposition regarding history as an incessant process of death, catastrophe, and ruin. For the author, "where we perceive a chain of events, he sees a single catastrophe, which keeps piling up rubble upon rubble and hurls it before his feet."

Michael sought (in his own words) to record reflections and shadows of a history, "wounds left on the body of the earth and humanity," knowing in advance that his records "only scratch the surface of a rich but brutal history" associated with mining activity in the Iron Quadrangle, Minas Gerais.

The region has experienced successive economic cycles. First, there was the gold rush (18th century), characterized by intense exploitation of nature and human beings. At the time of the first national census (1872), Minas Gerais had a total of 370,000 slaves, making it the largest slave-holding province in Brazil. After a long and painful period of decline that followed, with the depletion of gold veins, the iron cycle began, which continues today, perpetuating open fractures in the body of the land and its people.

It does not seem coincidental that one of the photographs in the series shows, in the foreground, the blurred silhouette of an angel. Its wings are open to the city of Belo Horizonte, to the mining region, to the Gerais. A land of so many contrasts, of so many achievements and failures, of so many ruins left behind.

Origens, primeira exposição do fotógrafo americano, Michael Naify, no Brasil (Rio de Janeiro), inicia-se com Autoretrato. A imagem representa um ser híbrido, parte homem, parte bicho, e uma flor nas mãos (copo-de-leite), que parece emergir, ereto, das sombrias paredes rochosas do interior de uma mina. Seus pés, cravados nos desmoronados de rochas no chão, dão a impressão de flutuar no espaço; seu corpo claro, em contraste com o escuro do ambiente, desprega-se do restante da imagem, como se projetado no ar.

Não passa despercebido o simbolismo da representação do artista, como um ser mutante. Mutante porque ao mesmo tempo preso ao solo e solto no espaço; confinado ao seu mundo e querendo ir além. Mutante porque o corpo humano e a cabeça de animal (porco) fazem lembrar o deus hindu Vishnu, que vem ao mundo como um avatar, podendo adquirir, entre outras formas, a um homem com cabeça de javali (matéria/ espírito, destruição/ criação).

O tema da destruição e das ruínas permeia o trabalho de criação de Michael. Suas fotografias (cianótipos), tiradas entre 2018 e 2024, na região de Estrada Real, Minas Gerais, retratam fragmentos de objetos, bocas de minas e estações abandonadas, brasões e emblemas antigos, construções depredadas, grilhões, instrumentos de intimidação e tortura, frutos caídos, detritos, corpos, faces. Mostram o outro lado, o lado perverso de uma história não contada, de uma memória de exploração e desolação que se pretende esquecida.

A natureza de sua narrativa iconográfica evoca a figura emblemática do Angelus Novus (desenho de Paul Klee, 1920), como utilizada por Walter Benjamin (1940), na sua conhecida proposição filosófica a respeito da história, como um processo incessante de morte, catástrofe e ruínas. Para o autor “onde percebemos uma cadeia de eventos, ele vê uma catástrofe única, que continua acumulando destroços sobre destroços e os atira diante de seus pés.”

Michael buscou (segundo suas próprias palavras) registrar reflexos e sombras de uma história”, “feridas deixadas no corpo da terra e da humanidade”, sabendo, de antemão, que seus registros “apenas arranham a superfície de uma história rica, mas brutal”, associada à atividade mineradora no Quadrilátero Ferrífero, Minas Gerais. A região presenciou sucessivos ciclos econômicos. Primeiro, o do ouro (século XVIII), caracterizado por intensa exploração da natureza e do ser humano. À época do primeiro censo nacional (1872), Minas Gerais registrava um total de 370 mil escravos, a maior província escravagista do Brasil. Após longo e doloroso período de decadência que se seguiu, com o esgotamento dos veios de ouro, iniciou-se o ciclo do ferro, em curso, que perpetua fraturas abertas no corpo da terra/povo.

Não parece por acaso, que uma das fotografias que compõem o conjunto apresente, em primeiro plano, a silhueta desfocada de um anjo. Suas asas estão abertas para a cidade de Belo Horizonte, para a região das minas, para as gerais. Terra de tantos contratos, de tantos feitos e desfeitos, de tantas ruínas deixadas para trás.

Three centuries later, the exploitative and predatory nature of the colonial slave trade remains engraved in social relations. In his observations and recordings, Michael demonstrates a level of empathy, sensitivity, and beauty that only a great artist is capable of.

He transforms ruins, waste, and vestiges into precious relics, beautiful objects of art. On the mythical journey he undertakes along the paths of the old/new Royal Road, he takes on the role of archaeologist/geologist, who searches for traces of the past/present, scattered and sometimes superimposed, in different stratigraphic layers of time/space. Perhaps for this reason, the work presented here escapes a logical, circumscribed, and comprehensible time, whether transversal or longitudinal, to enter into a temporality unique to the artist.

His immersion in the territory where mines are most widespread, “são gerais,” is profound. It even extends to the photographic reproduction technique used, cyanotypes stained with coffee powder. Cyanotype, which originated in the 19th century, uses elements extracted from iron ore, called iron salts, as the active ingredient in the printing process, which pull the color toward cyan, an intense indigo blue...

When the images, after being developed, are immersed for several hours in a bath of coffee (one of the state’s main export products), they are transformed, acquiring a slightly earthy and stained tone, diluting or blurring details, introducing an unsettling sense of incompleteness, of insufficiency. This provokes in the viewer a desire to go further, to uncover what has been lost, to recompose the irretrievably broken, shattered piece of porcelain.

Alertness, rescue, denunciation, recognition, but never acceptance or condescension. Evidence of what was, what could have been but wasn’t, what still is and isn’t. What will be?

The milk glass held inside an abandoned mine carries a message of hope.

As the great poet Drummond said, who saw his hometown ravaged by mining:

*Be completely silent, stop all business,
I assure you that a flower has been born.*

Carlos Drummond de Andrade

Passados três séculos, permanece, ainda hoje, gravado nas relações sociais, o caráter exploratório e predatório existente no passado colonial escravagista. No seu trabalho de observação e registro, Michael demonstra tal empatia, sensibilidade e beleza, que apenas um grande artista é capaz.

Ele transforma ruínas, resíduos e vestígios em relíquias preciosas, belos objetos de arte. Na viagem mítica que empreende pelos caminhos da antiga/nova Estrada Real, assume ele o papel de arqueólogo/ geólogo, que garimpa vestígios do passado/ presente, dispersos e por vezes sobrepostos, em diferentes camadas estratigráficas do tempo/ espaço. Talvez por essa razão, o trabalho ora apresentado escapa de um tempo lógico, circunscrito e compreensível, transversal ou longitudinal, para ingressar numa temporalidade própria do artista.

Sua imersão no território onde as minas são mais generalizadas, “são gerais” é profunda. Estende-se inclusive para a técnica de reprodução fotográfica utilizada, cianótipos manchados de pó de café. A cianotipia, originária do século XIX, utiliza, como ingrediente ativo do processo de impressão, elementos extraídos do minério de ferro, os chamados sais de ferro, que puxam a cor para o ciano, um azul índigo intenso...

Quando as imagens, após reveladas, são submetidas por algumas horas a um banho de café (um dos principais produtos de exportação do estado) elas se transformam, adquirindo um tom levemente terroso e manchado, diluindo ou desfazendo detalhes, introduzindo a inquietante sensação de incompletude, de insuficiência. Provocando no observador o desejo de ir além, de desvendar o que se perdeu, de recompor a peça de porcelana irremediavelmente quebrada, desfeita.

Alerta, resgate, denúncia, reconhecimento, mas nunca aceitação ou condescendência. Indícios do que foi, do que teria sido e não foi, do que ainda é e não é. Do que será?

O copo-de-leite que se segura no interior de uma mina abandonada carrega uma mensagem de esperança.

Como disse o grande poeta Drummond, que viu sua cidade natal ser dilapidada pela mineração:

*Be completely silent, stop all business,
I guarantee that a flower has been born.*

Carlos Drummond de Andrade

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